Everything About Your Husband's Care Feels Due Today: The First Three Things to Do

Three moves, in order, and what can sit on the list for now.

Your husband's discharge is set, the rehab wants an answer, the pharmacy has questions, and your daughter has a list. All of it seems to have landed on you, and all of it seems to be due today.

Some of it has a real date. Some of it only feels as if it does. These three moves, in this order, show you which is which.

1 Find the next decision and the date that goes with it

Go down the list and mark the items that are choices someone has to make. Beside each one, write the date you were given and who gave it. Where nobody gave you a date, write “no date given” and ask the person who is waiting for the answer. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Urgency comes from a date. A date someone gave you and a date the family has guessed look the same on a list until you write down where each one came from.

2 Write down what that decision is waiting on

Under the next decision, list what you'd need to know before making it. Beside each item, write who could settle it: the family, his doctor or nurse, the pharmacist, the discharge planner or social worker. Don't answer the medical ones yourself. Take them to the staff. [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A step taken before the thing it depends on is settled tends to get taken twice.

3 Write down who has offered what, and what you can take on yourself

List the tasks, and put a name beside only the ones somebody has agreed to. Look at how many carry your own name. Then tell the hospital staff plainly what you can do and what you can't. The Family Caregiver Alliance calls telling them about your limits extremely important. [3] [4]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST AARP's planning guide says caring for a family member can be too big a job for one person. Seeing the names on paper is where sharing it starts.

What can sit on the list for now

- The choices with no date beside them. Keep them written down, and ask whether there is a date.
- The chores that have no date of their own and that the next decision doesn't depend on.
- Putting every decision in its final order. That rests on your husband's whole situation, and it isn't a job for one person at the kitchen table.
- Who does what in the long run. This week you're only writing down what has been offered and agreed.
- The questions nobody can answer yet. On paper, with a name beside each one, they haven't been lost.

> **What doesn't go on a list**
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> Anything about his health, his medicines or his safety that worries you. That isn't an item to sort. Tell his nurse or his doctor. Medicare's discharge checklist tells families to write down the names and phone numbers of people to call with questions or concerns. If you don't have them, ask the staff for them.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't read the discharge papers, make any decision about your husband's care, or say how soon anything has to happen. It puts your first three moves in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've found the next decision, written down what it's waiting on, and noted who has offered what. The care interview adds the rest of the picture: it walks you through your husband's situation area by area, so that what comes first rests on all of it, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Writing down what you were told and who told you follows the Family Caregiver Alliance's guide to community resources. Writing your questions down and taking them to the staff follows Medicare's discharge checklist. Telling the hospital staff what you can and can't do follows the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide, and the point that care can be too big a job for one person is AARP's. The three moves and their order are ours.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
4. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families

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